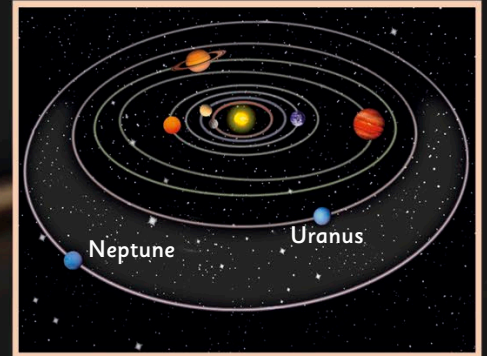


Distant twins

Uranus and Neptune are the seventh and eighth planets from the Sun, and are often referred to as twins because of their similar size and make-up.



Uranus and Neptune have atmospheres of hydrogen and helium gas, with traces of poisonous methane gas. Below this, the planets are covered in ice and slush.

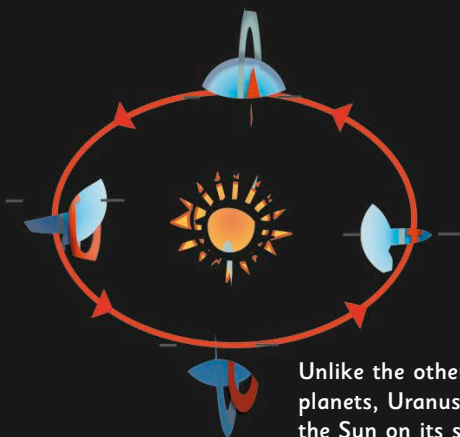
Uranus

Uranus was discovered in 1781 by William Herschel. He named it *Georgium Sidus*, or George's Star, in honour of King George III of Great Britain. This name was not popular, so it was later renamed Uranus.

Colours

Uranus looks a lot plainer than this false colour suggests, but this image gives astronomers a lot of information about the planet.

Uranus is encircled by 12 narrow rings made of rocks and dust.



Unlike the other planets, Uranus orbits the Sun on its side.

Unusual seasons

It takes 84 Earth years for Uranus to orbit the Sun. The poles each experience 42 years of "winter", then 42 years of "summer". For 21 of those years, they are each in continual darkness or light.

This close-up picture shows Uranus's rings.

